

Who/Whom That/Which

+ non-restrictive clause vs. restricting relative clause (defining relative clause)

A Quick-Reference Guide

1. Relative Clauses (restrictive vs. Non-restrictive)

	(Normal) non-restrictive clause parenthetical inserted side-comment		(Extra) restricting relative clause defining relative clause	
who whom	<u>Subject</u> <u>(actor)</u>	<u>Object</u> <u>(acted on)</u>	<u>Subject</u> <u>(actor)</u>	<u>Object</u> <u>(acted on)</u>
	who	whom	can't omit [who]	can omit [whom]
<i>crossover</i>	<i>can switch: that / who;</i> <i>who — which</i> <i>that / which</i>			
that, which	that or which [more British] can omit for some		not that use which] use comma(s) (or optional)	

2. Subject/Object

	Subject (actor)	Object (acted on)
who whom	who (often cannot omit)	(often omit) whom (technically)
Rule of Thumb: Who/Whom He/Him She/Her	who = he, she	whom = him, her

3. Technical Vs. Normal Language & Disagreements

	Technical	Normal Language
who whom	varies; some say "whom" is now archaic and no longer in use	dropped, substitute "that" for who or whom or just use who
that, which	varies + America vs. British	use whatever
commas	BBC says: defining relative clause does not need commas Chicago Manual of Style says: non-essential must use comma	

4. Comparatives and Superlatives, Comparisons: Samples

which	that
<u>Which</u> do you want? <u>Which</u> is smaller? <u>Which</u> is the smallest? I can't decide <u>which</u> is better. Let's determine <u>which</u> is the smallest.	I want <u>that</u> one. <u>That</u> is the best one. We determined that <u>that</u> one is the smallest.